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Your Sorrow Turned to Joy

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Your Sorrow Turned to Joy

Today's Reading: John 16:16-24

Hearing God's Voice for Today:

"You will weep and lament, but the world will rejoice. You will be sorrowful, but your sorrow will turn to joy. When a woman is giving birth, she has sorrow because her hour has come, but when she has delivered the baby, she no longer remembers the anguish, for joy that a human being has been born into the world...Ask, you will receive, that your joy may be full."

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Jesus knew that after the cross, his followers would be forlorn, weep, and lament. Conversely, the world would rejoice over his demise.

But Jesus also knew that his followers' sadness wouldn't last forever. He wanted them to know their sorrow would eventually change to joy.

Jesus used contrasts to teach us. How can we know joy without sadness? Or how can we know happiness without heartache? It's one way he is able to take that which is evil and use it for good.

Jesus then gave his disciples an illustration to make his point—he referred to an event that happens daily. He asked them to remember what happens in childbirth.

When a mother is delivering her baby, the pain is excruciating. It increases with each contraction as the hour of delivery approaches. Her sorrow becomes increasingly greater.

But after the baby is delivered and is placed on her chest, the pain is forgotten and she is overcome with joy.

That was what happened with the disciples. They knew great pain after the cross and thought they had no hope. Their sorrow increased with every passing hour.

Jesus then appeared to them in his resurrection body. When they realized he was alive, their sorrow was immediately transformed into joy. New life and hope pulsed in their veins. Their joy became their strength.

You may think that your present situation is hopeless. The mountain before you appears too steep to be climbed. Sorrow fills your heart as you face the seemingly impossible.

Don't be discouraged. Don't give up. The Father is able to make lemonade out of your lemons. He can take your dramas and give daylight. He is able to do exceedingly and abundantly more than you could ever hope for or imagine. During your time of discouragement, remember a mother giving birth to her child. Your child is coming. Your deliverance is just around the corner.

Persevere in your prayers. Remember how Jesus has answered you in the past. When you ask and you receive an answer, joy fills your heart. Sorrow is immediately turned to joy. In him your heart rejoices, for you trust in his name. You may plant in tears, but your harvest will come with shouts of joy. You may weep as you plant the seed, but you will sing as you return with the harvest. Therefore, be overwhelmed with joy in the Lord your God. Rejoice in the Lord always. Let me say it again: Rejoice!¹⁰

He will keep you from falling away and will bring you with great joy into his glorious presence without a single fault.¹¹

Jesus' plans for you are good. He will use your sorrow for good.

It's always darkest before dawn.

Your joy will come in the morning.

[from "*Hearing the Voice of God*" by Pastor David Chadwick, Moments of Hope Church, Charlotte, NC]